Systolic blood pressure is the highest pressure in the arteries, due to contraction of the heart.

Diastolic pressure is the lowest pressure.

It occurs between the heartbeats

Pulse pressure is the difference between the systolic and diastolic pressures

It is normally about 35 and is a measure of the hearts strength

Articles Required:

- Sphygmomanometer: To measure arterial pressure
- Bladder and cuff: To exert equal pressure around the artery being ausultated.
- Stethoscope: To auscultate arterial pressure waves
- Pen, pencil and flow chart: For timely documentation of findings.

Procedure:

1. Explain the procedure to the patient, and have him seated by a table or lying down, with the arm supported and relaxed.



2. Place the centre of the cuff of the BP apparatus over the brachial artery and wrap it smoothly and firmly around the patient's arm 5 cm above the elbow tuck the end in neatly.
3. Find the brachial pulse with the fingers and place the stethoscope over it.
4. Close the screw valve, and inflate the cuff until the pulse disappears and above that about 20 mm mercury.
5. Open the valve slowly, and listen for the first sound while watching the manometer reading. The first sound gives the systolic reading. As air escapes the sounds become louder and clearer.
6. Continue to let air out slowly. As you listen the sounds suddenly become dull, and at then point take the diastolic reading.
7. Allow all the air to escape and the mercury to fall to zero.
8. Repeat the procedure if there is any doubt about the reading
9. Record the reading. The systolic pressure is always written over the diastolic pressure eg. 120/80 mm Hg.
10. Remove the cuff from the patients arm roll and replace in the box.



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